Redrawing Diaspora

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The term diaspora is usually reserved for those who cross national borders. A new study, however, broadens the frame. 'The Internal and International Diasporas of India', published in the *Sociological Bulletin*, is the first attempt to sketch a conceptual framework for both kinds of movement. Its author, Chinmay Tumbe, an associate professor at IIM Ahmedabad, charts migration by language and estimates that, in 2011, over 60 million Indians lived in 'internal' diasporas, nearly three times as many as abroad. For every major linguistic group, except Malayalam and Tamil, the domestic diaspora outweighs the overseas one. ■

GLOBAL FOOTPRINT

Countries with the highest Indian overseas population

35.4 mn
Total worldwide

USA	UAE	Canada
5.6	3.9	3.6

Malaysia	Saudi Arabia	Sri Lanka
2.9	2.7	1.6

Figures (in million) include NRIs and PIOs; MEA data as of Jan. 2025 (Rajya Sabha reply, Aug. 21, 2025)

CITIES OF MANY TONGUES

A third of India's internal diaspora is dispersed across 10 largest cities



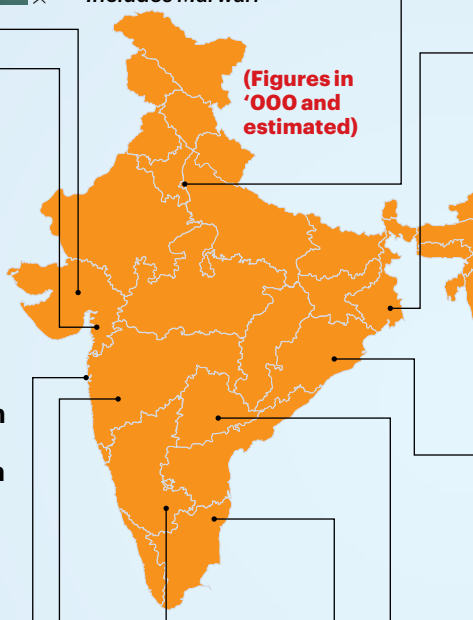


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JAIPUR

Hindi*	4,900
Urdu	130
Sindhi	90
Punjabi	30
Bengali	20
Gujarati	10

**Includes Marwari*



AHMEDABAD

Gujarati	4,500
Hindi	700
Urdu	300
Sindhi	120
Marathi	100
Malayalam + Tamil	20

There are far more non-resident Gujaratis within India than abroad, and this holds true even if you exclude Mumbai

SURAT

Gujarati	2,800
Hindi	700
Marathi	400
Odia	100
Urdu	100
Telugu	30

Sindhis numbered around 3 million in 2011, rooted in post-Partition migration from Sindh, with strong bases in Mumbai and Ahmedabad



BENGALURU

Kannada	4,100
Telugu	1,200
Urdu	1,000
Hindi	240
Malayalam	200
Tamil	125



MUMBAI

Marathi	8,900
Hindi	3,900
Gujarati	1,800
Sindhi	440
Telugu	400
Tamil	400

PUNE

Marathi	5,700
Hindi	700
Urdu	170
Telugu	150
Kannada	100
Gujarati	100

Mumbai is India's migration capital, hosting the largest communities of Tamils, Malayalis, Kannadigas, Gujaratis and Hindi speakers



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● 'Native speakers'
Source: Census 2001 & 2011, language data files